

A Friend in Need

Somerset Maugham

1 For thirty years now I have been studying my fellowmen. I do not know very much about them. I **shrug my shoulders**(耸肩) when people tell me that their first impressions of a person are always right. I think they must have small insight or great **vanity**ⁱ. For my own part I find that the longer I know people the more they **puzzle**(=confuse) me.

i. Vanity has two basic meanings: 1) something that is vain, empty, 虚荣, 浮华; 2) inflated pride, 表示膨胀的自信, 自负。本文取第二层意义。

2 These reflections have **occurred** to me because I read in this morning's paper that Edward Hyde Burton had died at Kobe. He was a merchant and he had been in business in Japan for many years. I knew him very little, but he interested me because once he gave me a great surprise. Unless I had heard the story from his own lips, I should never have believed that he was capable of such an actionⁱⁱ. It was more **startling**(=surprising, astonishing) because both in appearance and manner he suggested a very definite type. Here if ever was **a man all of a piece**ⁱⁱⁱ. He was a tiny little fellow, not much more than five feet four in height, and very **slender**(=thin, slim), with white hair, a red face much **wrinkled**(being full of wrinkles 布满皱纹的), and blue eyes. I suppose he was about sixty when I knew him. He was always **neatly** and quietly dressed **in accordance with**^{iv} his age and **station**(=status).

ii. 此处作者用了虚拟语气:

Unless I had heard the story from his own lips, I **should never have believed** that he was capable of such an action.

我们也可以换一种说法:

If I hadn't heard the story from his own lips, I should never have believed that he was capable of such an action.

还可以改成:

Had I not heard the story from his own lips, I should never have believed...

无论如何改写, 主句和从句都是对过去的虚拟, 表示与过去的事实相反。

iii. Here if ever was a man all of a piece. 这是一个副词 Here 提前的倒装句。它原来的语句顺序是 If ever a man all of a piece was here. 假设曾经真有这么个人出现的话。同学们了解其语序, 并且学会 all of a piece 这样的表达即可。

iv. Be in accordance with 和我们上节课学到的 be at odds with 为一对反义短语。

3 Though his offices were in Kobe, Burton often came down to Yokohama. I happened on one occasion to be spending a few days there, waiting for a ship, and I was introduced to him at the British Club. We played bridge together. He played a good game and a **generous** one. He did not talk very much, either then or later when we were having drinks, but what he said was **sensible**^v. He had a quiet, dry humor. He seemed to be popular at the club and afterwards, when he had gone, they described him as one of the best. It happened that we were both staying at the Grand Hotel and next day he asked me to dine with him. I met his wife, fat, elderly, and smiling, and his two daughters. It was **evidently** a united and **affectionate**(=loving) family. I think the **chief**(=main) thing that **struck**(=impress) me about Burton was his kindness. There was something very **pleasing**(=pleasant) in his **mild**(温和的, 其反义词为 **wild**, 放荡不羁的) blue eyes. His voice was gentle; you could not imagine that he could possibly raise it in anger; his smile was **benign**(=loving, benevolent 仁爱的, 慈祥的). Here was a man who attracted you because you felt in him a real love for his fellows. At the

same time he liked his game of cards and his cocktail, he could tell with point a good and **spicy** story^{vi}, and in his youth he had been something of an **athlete**. He was a rich man and he had made every penny himself. I suppose one thing that made you like him was that he was so small and **frail**(瘦弱的, **fragile, weak**); he **aroused** your **instincts** of protection^{vii}. You felt that he could not **bear** to hurt a fly.^{viii}

v. 老师这里详细讲解一下由 sense 派生来的各类形容词。Sense 的不同含义派生出了不同的形容词。这就如同 succeed, 该词的“成功”这层含义, 派生出 successful, successfully; 而该词的“继任”含义, 派生出 successive, successively, 表示连续的, 继任的。

Sense 第一层含义为感官。We have five senses: sight, touch, sound, taste, smell. 所以, 和感官相关, 感官上的, 我们有 **sensual** 和 **sensory**; 如果一个器官过于敏锐, 就变成了 **sensitive**, 敏感的;

Sense 第二层含义理性, 理智。E.g. He was a man of sense. = He was a **sensible**/reasonable/rational man. 他是个理智的人;

Sense 第三层含义为感知, 所以, 当一个事物给人带来了巨大的触动, 能引起共鸣, 我们叫它 **sensational**, 表示引起轰动的, 触发神经的。例如, 去年我们学到的 Mystery Meat, 劣质肉那篇文章。Horsemeat was detected in Burger King burgers! That's sensational news! 马肉居然用于制作汉堡! 真是惊见骇闻!

vi. He could tell with point a good and spicy story. 这里的 tell with point 怎么理解呢? Point 表示点, 那么 tell a story with point 即能够重点明确地讲故事, 或者讲故事能讲到点上。那么其实也就表示能生动地讲一个故事。Good and spicy story 这里要两个词放在一起理解, spicy 表示辛辣的(类似我们还学到一个 juicy, 表示带有煽动性的, 使人愤怒的), a good and spicy story means a story which is attractive and exciting, 他能生动地讲一个**饶有趣味**、**后劲十足**的故事。

vii. Arouse here means stir, raise 激起; He aroused your instincts of protection, 即**他能激起你的保护欲**。

viii. He could not bear to hurt a fly. 他无法忍心去伤害一只苍蝇。E.g. She could not bear to see him suffer in front of the TV every time his favourite team lost.

4 One afternoon I was sitting in the lounge of the Grand Hotel when Burton came in and **seated**(该词与 sit 的区别在于, **seat** 是一个及物动词) himself in the chair next to mine.

5 'What do you say to a little drink?'

6 He **clapped** his hands for a boy and ordered two gin fizzes. As the boy brought them a man passed along the street outside and seeing me waved his hand.

7 'Do you know Turner?' said Burton as I nodded a greeting.

8 'I've met him at the club. I'm told he's a remittance man.'

9 'Yes, I believe he is. We have a good many here.'

10 'He plays bridge well.'

11 'They generally do. There was a fellow here last year, **oddly**(=strangely) enough a **namesake**(同名者, 在本文中, 他俩同姓) of mine, who was the best bridge player I ever met. I suppose you never came across him in London. Lenny Burton he called himself. I believe he'd belonged to some very good clubs.'

12 'No, I don't believe I remember the name.'

13 'He was quite a **remarkable** player. He seemed to have an **instinct** about the cards. It was

uncanny.^{ix} I used to play with him a lot. He was in Kobe for some time.'

ix. Uncanny means being beyond what is normal, usual and expected. It was uncanny 中的 it 为前指代词, 指代的是 his instinct about the cards. 我们可以翻译成: 这简直神了。

14 Burton sipped(抿一口) his gin fizz.

15 'It's rather a funny story,' he said. 'He wasn't a bad chap. I liked him. He was always well-dressed and smart-looking. He was handsome in a way with curly hair and pink-and-white cheeks. Women thought a lot of him. There was no harm in him, you know, he was only wild. Of course he drank too much. Those sort of fellows always do. A bit of money used to come on for him once a quarter(一个季度) and he made a bit more by card-playing. He won a good deal of mine, I know that.'

16 Burton gave a kindly chuckle(咯咯笑)^x. I knew from my own experience that he could lose money at bridge with a good grace(generously, gracefully 慷慨大方地, 优雅而不计较地). He stroked his shaven chin with his thin hand; the veins stood out on it and it was almost transparent.

x. Chuckle 表示用手捂着笑; 类似的笑声还包括水流流进洗碗槽槽口的咕噜声 gurgling, 它也用于形容婴幼儿的咕咕笑声; 此外还有 tickling, tickle 表示挠痒, 那么 tickling 是挠痒这个动作的结果, 表示被挠痒时的“吱吱笑”, 它还可以写成 giggling; belly laugh 表示捧腹大笑; horselaugh 表示傻笑, 如图:



17 'I suppose that is why he came to me when he went broke(go broke, 俗语, 表示没钱了), that and the fact that he was a namesake of mine. He came to see me in my office one day and asked me for a job. I was rather surprised. He told me that there was no more money coming from home and he wanted to work. I asked him how old he was.

18 "'Thirty-five," he said.

19 "'And what have you been doing hitherto(here+to, to here, 即到目前为止)?" I asked him.

20 "'Well, nothing very much," he said.

21 'I couldn't help laughing.

22 "'I'm afraid I can't do anything for you just yet," I said. "Come back and see me in another thirty-five years, and I'll see what I can do."

23 'He didn't move. He went rather pale. He hesitated for a moment and then he told me that he had had bad luck at cards for some time. He hadn't been willing to stick to(addictive to) bridge, he'd been playing poker, and he'd got trimmed^{xi}. He hadn't a penny. He'd pawned everything he had. He couldn't pay his hotel bill and they wouldn't give him any more credit. He was down and out. If he couldn't get something to do he'd have to commit suicide.

xi. 这里是 trim 的不常见用法。Trim here means to cheat. He got trimmed means he got cheated. 他被骗了。

24 'I looked at him for a bit. I could see now that he was all to pieces(他支离破碎). He'd

been drinking more than usual and he looked fifty. The girls wouldn't have thought so much of him if they'd seen him then.

25 "Well isn't there anything you can do except play cards?" I asked him.

26 "I can swim," he said.

27 "Swim!"

28 'I could hardly believe my ears; it seemed such an **insane(=crazy)** answer to give.

29 "I swam for my university."

30 'I got some **glimmering(=hint)** of what he was driving at^{xii}. I've known too many men who were little tin gods^{xiii} at their university to be impressed by it.^{xiv}

xii. The whole sentence can be paraphrased into "I could vaguely perceive what he hoped to express."我隐约猜到 he 到底想要传达什么。

xiii. Tin is not precious. 锡为一种常见的、廉价金属, tin gods refer to those who are of minor importance but feel a sense of self-importance. 自命不凡的人。

xiv. 这句话是一个 too...to 结构的句子, 我们将它的插入语删除: I've known too many men (~~who were little tin gods at their university~~) to be impressed by it. 变成了 I've known too many men to be impressed by it. 我见识了太多这类人, 这点伎俩几乎打动不了我。

31 "'I was a pretty good swimmer myself when I was a young man," I said.

32 'Suddenly I had an idea.'

33 Pausing in his story, Burton turned to me.

34 'Do you know Kobe?' he asked.

35 'No,' I said, 'I passed through it once, but I only spent a night there.'

36 'Then you don't know the Shioya Club. When I was a young man I swam from there round the beacon and landed at the creek of Tarumi. It's over three miles and it's rather difficult **on account of(=because of)** the currents round the beacon. Well, I told my young namesake about it and I said to him that if he'd(=would) do it I'd(=would) give him a job.

37 'I could see he **was rather taken aback(be taken aback=be shocked, astonished)**.

38 "'You say you're a swimmer," I said.

39 "'I'm not in very good condition," he answered.

40 'I didn't say anything. I shrugged my shoulders. He looked at me for a moment and then he nodded.

41 "'All right," he said. "When do you want me to do it?"

42 'I looked at my watch. It was just after ten.

43 "'The swim shouldn't take you much over an hour and a quarter. I'll drive round to the creek at half past twelve and meet you. I'll take you back to the club to dress and then we'll have lunch together."

44 "'Done," he said.

45 'We shook hands. I wished him good luck and he left me. I had a lot of work to do that morning and I only just managed to get to the creek at Tarumi at half past twelve. But I needn't have hurried; he never turned up.'

46 'Did he funk(give up 因畏惧而放弃) it at the last moment?' I asked.

47 'No, he didn't funk it. He started all right. But of course he'd **ruined** his **constitution(=body)** by drink and **dissipation(wildness, 放任, 放荡)**. The **currents** round the beacon were more than he could manage. We didn't get the body for about three days.'

48 I didn't say anything for a moment or two. I was a trifle(=slightly, to a small degree) shocked. Then I asked Burton a question.

49 'When you made him that offer of a job, did you know he'd be drowned?'

50 He gave a little mild chuckle and he looked at me with those kind and candid(=honest, sincere) blue eyes of his. He rubbed(=stroke) his chin with his hand.

51 'Well, I hadn't got a vacancy in my office at the moment.'